# THE IAF: WINGS TO RECKON

The Indian Air Force can project power through a wide swathe of the Indian Ocean Region. These are the platforms



## FIGHTER JETS

### RAFALE

No. of squadrons: **2**

The French-origin Rafale is a 4.5 generation, twin-engine omnirole fighter equipped to carry out a range of missions, including in-depth strikes, anti-ship attacks and nuclear deterrence. The IAF will acquire 114 more omnirole fighters

### MIRAGE 2000

No. of squadrons: **3**

The French Mirage-2000 is one of IAF's most versatile aircraft. It played a decisive role in the 1999 Kargil War and Balakot air strike in 2019

### SUKHOI 30MKI

No. of squadrons: **12**

The Sukhoi Su-30MKI is a multirole combat fighter aircraft. Jets of the new squadron carry BrahMos cruise missiles

### JAGUAR

No. of squadrons: **6**

IAF uses an upgraded version of the British fighter

### MIG 29

No. of squadrons: **3**

Forms a second line of defence after Su-30MKI. IAF uses the upgraded MiG-29 UPG

### MIG 21

No. of squadrons: **3**

The MiG-21 Bison formed the backbone of the IAF. To be phased out by 2025

### LCA TEJAS

No. of squadrons: **2**

A 4.5 generation multi-role fighter for offensive air support, close combat and ground attack roles



## TRANSPORT AIRCRAFT

### C-17 III GLOBEMASTER, C-130J-30 SUPER HERCULES

American transport planes ideal for both long- and short-range operations. The IAF operates 11 and 12 of these aircraft, respectively

### ILYUSHIN IL-76, ANTONOV AN-32 AND DORNIER DO 228

The Russian origin Il-76 and AN-32 are workhorses of the transport fleet. Ideal for short-haul operations, the German origin Do 228s are being upgraded by HAL. IAF has 14, 105 and 6 of these

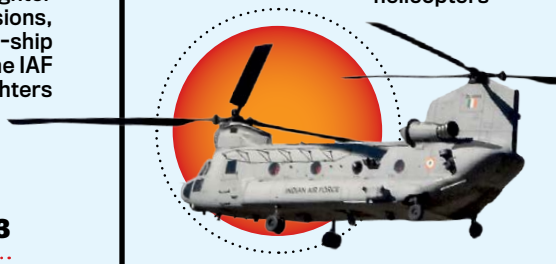
### C-295

Can take off and land from unprepared airfields, carry 9 tonnes of payload, 71 soldiers. All 56 to be delivered by 2031

## HELICOPTERS

### CH-47F CHINOOK

IAF operates 15 of these US-made transport helicopters



### MI-26, MI-8, MI-17, MI-17 1V AND MI-17 V5

Russian transport helicopters. IAF has approx. 250 of these

### AH-64E APACHE

IAF has 22 Apache, one of the world's most advanced attack helicopters

### LCH PRACHAND AND ALH RUDRA

Prachand is the only attack copter to operate at 5,000 metres; IAF operates 10 Prachands and 16 Rudras, will get 66 and 50 more of the two, respectively

## UAVs

### SEARCHER II AND HERON

Both are Israeli drones used for intelligence, reconnaissance and surveillance missions. IAF has 108 Searchers and 90 Herons

Vayu Bhawan (the IAF headquarters) in New Delhi seems to be brimming with confidence of late. Former IAF chief Air Chief Marshal Birender Singh Dhanoa (retd) boldly claims that India's adversaries will think twice before starting a war as the IAF now has a major combat edge in the region. The force is high on training and motivation too—much-needed skills have also been acquired through regular exercises with Western air forces like the US Air Force, the Royal Air Force and the French Air Force. To cap it all, the US-based World Directory of Modern Military Aircraft (WDMMA) placed the IAF third in its global air powers ranking for the second consecutive year in 2023. To evaluate each air force, the WDMMA analyses them not merely by the number of planes but also by the quality and diversity of its stock. The world's fourth largest air force was ranked above China and the Japan Air Self-Defense Force (JASDF), the Israeli Air Force and the French Air and Space Force.